



# IF I WERE YOU, I'D MAKE A BIT OF A SCENE

PEOPLE ON SUNDAY / 1930

## IN CONTEXT

### GENRE

**Silent drama**

### DIRECTORS

**Robert Siodmak,  
Curt Siodmark**

### WRITERS

**Curt Siodmark, Robert  
Siodmark, Edgar G. Ulmer,  
Billy Wilder**

### STARS

**Erwin Splettstößer, Annie  
Schreyer, Wolfgang von  
Waltershausen, Christl  
Ehlers, Brigitte Borchert**

### BEFORE

**1927** Walther Ruttmann's silent documentary *Berlin: Symphony of a Great City* chronicles one day in Berlin to an orchestral score.

### AFTER

**1948** Vittorio De Sica's *The Bicycle Thief*, a key Italian neorealist movie, tells an everyday story shot entirely on location.

**G**erman cinema in the 1920s and 30s was noted for its style and technical expertise. But *People on Sunday* (*Menschen am Sonntag*) is pioneering in a very different way, creating a fluid, freewheeling movie aimed at realism.

Filmmakers Robert Siodmak and Edgar G. Ulmer, then both novices, would later carve out a career in Hollywood making tense thrillers, but *People on Sunday* is the polar opposite. It is also very different from the later works of its screenwriter Billy Wilder, who developed its documentary style from reportage by Siodmak's brother Curt, soon to write many of Universal Studios' horror pictures.

## A movie experiment

The movie's subtitle was "a film without actors." It follows 24 hours in the lives of five Berliners, played by nonactors in roles based on their real lives. Wine merchant Wolfgang flirts with movie extra Christl. They arrange to meet in the lake resort of Nikolassee. Later that day Wolfgang

visits Erwin, a cabdriver, and his wife Annie, a model. He invites them to the lake, but, after an argument, Erwin leaves Annie behind to join Wolfgang, Christl, and Brigitte, a salesclerk.

In retrospect, the artlessness of what happens next in the film is truly affecting, given that the movie's makers would all be forced into exile before the decade was out. There is no cynicism, only the pathos of its characters' optimistic faith in the often-repeated word "tomorrow." ■

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We'd sit at a nearby table while they'd decide what to do that day. It was completely improvised.

**Brigitte Borchert**

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**What else to watch:** *The Bicycle Thief* (1948, pp.94–97) ■ *À bout de souffle* (1960, pp.166–67) ■ *Saturday Night and Sunday Morning* (1960, pp.168–69)